

How Hard Was Your Ride, Really?

A rider's guide to rating effort (RPE) accurately

Why this matters

After every ride, Alpine AI Coach asks you one simple question: **how hard was it, from 1 to 10?**

That number — your RPE (Rating of Perceived Exertion) — is the single most important piece of data you give your coach. It drives:

- How much training you get next week
- When your plan schedules recovery
- Whether the system thinks you're adapting well or heading toward overtraining

If the number is inflated, your plan gets worse. The system will think you're overloaded, cut your training back, and trigger recovery weeks you don't need. You'll get an easier plan than you can handle — and progress slower than you should.

Honest scores = a plan that actually fits you. **There are no points for suffering.**

The #1 mistake riders make

"I rode 90 minutes and it was tough. That's a 9, right?"

Almost certainly not. Here's why:

RPE 9 means near-maximal effort — the kind you can only sustain for a few minutes before your body forces you to stop. Nobody rides 90 minutes at RPE 9. It's physiologically impossible.

What usually happened instead: - The ride was *long*, and long rides are tiring — but **tiring is not the same as intense** - There was one brutal climb or sprint that *felt* like a 9 — but the other 80 minutes were a 4 - You finished proud of the effort — and the pride inflated the number

The rule: rate how the ride felt overall, not the hardest moment and not how tired you are afterward.

The scale, anchored to the talk test

The most reliable way to judge effort is simple: **could you talk while riding?**

RPE	Feels like	Talk test
1–2	Very easy	Recovery spin. Chatting effortlessly the whole time.
3–4	Easy	Conversational pace. Full sentences, no strain.
5–6	Moderate	Working. Breathing deeper, short sentences only.
7–8	Hard	A few words at a time. You couldn't hold this for long.
9–10	Very hard	Can't speak. Only sustainable for minutes. 10 = all-out sprint, seconds not minutes.

A sanity check on duration

How long can each effort level actually be sustained? Roughly:

RPE	Realistic maximum duration at that effort
3–4	All day
5–6	A few hours
7	~30–60 minutes (a genuinely hard hour)
8	~10–20 minutes
9	A few minutes
10	Seconds

If you're about to log **"2 hours at RPE 9"** — stop. That combination doesn't exist. The ride was probably a 5–6 overall with some hard moments.

Worked examples

Example 1: The long weekend ride 3 hours steady with your group, one 20-minute climb where you were breathing hard, coffee stop, easy ride home. You were wiped out afterward.

✗ Tempting answer: 8 ("I was exhausted!") ✓ Honest answer: **4–5**. Mostly conversational, one hard section. Fatigue from duration is not intensity.

Example 2: The interval session 60 minutes total: warm-up, 5 × 4 minutes where you couldn't speak, easy spins between, cool-down.

✗ Tempting answer: 9 ("The intervals were maximal!") ✓ Honest answer: **7**. The intervals were 9, but half the session was easy riding. Rate the whole session.

Example 3: The race 90-minute criterium, constantly on the limit, gasping in the wheels, sprint at the end.

✓ Honest answer: **8–9**. This is what very hard actually looks like — and notice it's a *race*, not a training ride. If your training rides regularly score like your races, something is off.

Example 4: The recovery spin 40 minutes flat, legs spinning lightly, heart rate barely elevated.

✓ Honest answer: **1–2**. Don't inflate it because "it still counts as training." It does count — as recovery, which is exactly what the plan needs to see.

Quick self-checks before you log

Ask yourself these three questions:

1. **Could I have talked?** Full sentences → 3–4. Short sentences → 5–6. Barely words → 7–8. Nothing → 9+.
2. **Could I have kept going at that effort?** For hours → it wasn't above 6. For an hour → max 7. Only minutes → 9.
3. **Am I rating the whole ride, or just the worst moment?** One hard climb doesn't make a hard ride.

And one mindset check: **a low RPE is not an insult to your effort**. An easy ride done properly is a *successful* training session. The riders who progress fastest are the ones whose easy days are genuinely easy — that's what makes their hard days count.

What happens to your number

For the curious: your RPE is multiplied by the ride duration to compute your **session load** (sRPE). A 60-minute ride at RPE 5 = 300 load points. The system tracks your weekly load, compares it to what you're adapted to, and adjusts next week's plan.

This is why one inflated number matters: logging that 60-minute ride as an 8 instead of a 5 tells the system you did 480 points of load instead of 300 — a 60% error. Do that a few times a week and your training history becomes fiction, and your plan is built on fiction.

Accurate beats impressive. Every time.

TL;DR

- Rate the **whole ride**, not the hardest moment
 - **Tired ≠ intense** — long easy rides are still easy
 - Use the **talk test**: full sentences = 3–4, short sentences = 5–6, few words = 7–8, silence = 9+
 - RPE 9–10 is only sustainable for **minutes** — it can't describe a long ride
 - Most training rides land between **3 and 6**. That's normal, correct, and how you get faster
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